DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Is Suffering a Punishment or a Cleansing?

Derech Hashem 2:2:4-5

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 2, end of paragraph 4 and paragraph 5 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 3 May 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap

The class began halfway through paragraph 4. The Rabbi reviewed: the ultimate goal is the Kibbutz HaShelemim, a community of the perfect who will enjoy the World to Come. Because of free will, most people have both good and bad in them, and justice cannot simply follow the majority, ignoring either a person's minority of bad or his minority of good. So Hashem looks at the whole person and decides who he is, and the remainder is dealt with elsewhere. A good person's bad is cleansed in this world, or, if it is more intense, in Gehinnom. A bad person's good is rewarded in this world.

The Ramhal concluded with a very important sentence: very few people are denied a place in the World to Come altogether, because between this world and the world of souls there are sufficient means of cleansing. One pure misvah guarantees a portion. Gehinnom lasts at most twelve months, because anyone who needs more than that is "too bruised," and like a rotten apple is simply thrown away.

Mashiah is not the World to Come

A participant asked: if everyone becomes perfect in the World to Come, will the Torah and the Third Temple become redundant? The Rabbi said he was confusing the Third Temple with the World to Come.

"Let's get something very clear." Mashiah, the Third Temple and the return of prophecy are minuscule compared with the World to Come. If Mashiah came tonight, in the year 5781, there would be 219 years of messianic times, but all of that happens in this physical world, with people eating and drinking, doing business and learning Torah. At the end of six thousand years it all goes: Mashiah, the Temple, prophecy. In the World to Come there are only human beings with a lofty, almost soul-like body, connecting with Hashem.

The Rambam writes, based on the Gemara, that the messianic era is essentially political independence: Israel reigns supreme, but life continues. Mashiah is a prelude that ushers in the World to Come, and as time goes on, the period of Mashiah becomes shorter. The Rabbi noted that the Ramhal does not discuss Mashiah in the body of this book at all, only in a page

among some additional paragraphs at the end. "When we pray for Mashiah, deeper, what we mean is the World to Come," because it begins the process of the world becoming purified.

Only Hashem knows the details

The Ramhal says that all these details, who reaches the World to Come, who needs suffering in this world, who needs it in the next, are known only to the true Judge, who knows the true nature of every deed, in all its levels and details.

The Rabbi gave an example: two people pray every morning. Do you know how much kavanah, love or fear is in each prayer? "All you can see is the exterior. You can't see the interior motive." Even when a beit din must punish a murderer on the testimony of two witnesses, we still do not know whether he is truly a rasha.

All we can know are the general principles. The foundation is that there must be a complete and perfect community fit to cleave to Hashem forever, and everything we have discussed serves that. The exact details no one in this world can answer.

He applied this to the tragedy at Meron, which had happened a few days earlier. When rabbis announce that it happened because of this or that, "it's very dangerous," and he strongly disagreed. It is always right to say that we should all work on ourselves, but to pinpoint the cause of a tragedy shows ignorance. "Whenever you hear these kinds of things... know that that person is talking nonsense."

Paragraph 5: reward is who you become

Paragraph 5 repeats a key idea from Part 1 because it is so important. Reward is not an arbitrary payment for good deeds. "The reward of a misvah is the misvah itself." You do a misvah and become a better person, and so you cleave more to Hashem and enjoy more in the World to Come. Every sin makes you darker and further from Hashem.

"We have to get rid of this childish mindset." He called it one of the disasters of Judaism today that people learn childish concepts at school and are never taught them again at a deeper level, so they go through life thinking that what they learned as children is Judaism. The Rambam writes that we teach children with rewards of nuts, and later money, but an adult must know that this is not how the world works.

He returned to the queen: the more refined you become, the more time she wants to spend with you. But you may learn all the etiquette of a gentleman and then behave like an animal at the pub, and that needs dealing with.

The Ramhal says the good deeds a person does become part of him and refine him, and evil deeds bring into him cloudiness and darkness, all precisely measured. A saddik who has absorbed much light still has some darkness from his few bad deeds, and as long as that darkness is in him, how can he cleave to Hashem? In His great kindness Hashem provided a way of purification: suffering, which removes the darkness so that he remains bright and fit for closeness in the World to Come. The suffering is in proportion to the deeds. If the physical sufferings of this world are not enough, there are spiritual ones.

Not a punishment

"It's not that Hashem is vengeful... or Hashem is rewarding you because you were a good boy." The pain of this world or of Gehinnom is not a punishment; it is what is needed to get you clean. If you are in Gehinnom, you are on the right track: you are a bruised apple with much cleaning to do, but you have not been thrown out. If someone does not go through Gehinnom, it is either because he was so good that this world sufficed, or so bad that he was simply discarded.

For those with so much bad that this world will not suffice, Hashem devised Gehinnom. The Ramhal calls its pains "sufferings of the soul," which confirms that there is no physical fire or snow; it is deep, intense shame according to the level of correction needed. Asked why Hashem did not make this world enough, the Rabbi said simply that it is not enough for such a person: "He's really bad, but he's not so bad, don't forget."

Kaddish. We say Kaddish for everyone because we do not know. Kaddish does not help the person who is rotten through, nor is it about the afflictions of this world; it is for the person in between, in Gehinnom.

Menasheh. Asked whether King Menasheh, who repented in captivity, would still go to Gehinnom, the Rabbi said, "Who knows?" We know only the principles and cannot make these judgments, whether about him or about anyone we see suffering.

Different seats

One misvah done properly, without any taint, and "you're in," part of the community of the perfect, even if you have to spend twelve months in Gehinnom for your pride. But those who needed cleansing will not be at the same level as those who went straight through with little cleansing. There are levels in the World to Come: a front-row or a back-row audience with the queen. Even the back row has to be vetted to be in the same room, "but at least you're there."

Summary

- Mashiah and the Third Temple belong to this world and are a prelude to the World to Come, which is far greater.
- Only Hashem knows how each person's deeds are judged; we must never claim to know why a tragedy happened.
- The reward of a misvah is the person you become; sins leave darkness that must be removed before one can cleave to Hashem.
- Suffering in this world and in Gehinnom is cleansing, not punishment, measured to what each person needs.
- Everyone who reaches the World to Come has a place, but at different levels of closeness.

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